



Eastern China and Korea

CHINA HAS A LARGE population of almost 1.4 billion, with two-thirds living in eastern China. For thousands of years, powerful emperors ruled China. During this period, Chinese civilization was very advanced, but much of the population lived in poverty. In 1949, after a communist revolution, the People's Republic of China was established. Food, education, and health care became available to more people, but there was also a loss of freedom. Today, Chinese people have more freedom, but the government still has tight control over their lives. The Korean peninsula is divided politically into north and south, and political tensions continue to exist between the two governments. Since 1949, Taiwan has been in dispute with China over who governs the mountainous island of Taiwan.

NEW YEAR CELEBRATIONS

Chinese New Year, also known as the Spring Festival, is the country's most important festival. It is usually held in January or February. Good-luck messages decorate buildings and there are feasts, fireworks, fairs, and processions. People wear red clothes for good luck and give gifts of coins to symbolize wealth.



Chinese New Year parade



HONG KONG

For 100 years, Hong Kong was a British colony. Then, in 1997, it was returned to China. These small islands are some of the most densely populated parts of the world. Most people live and work in high-rise buildings. It has a prosperous economy at the heart of global finance and the people there have one of the world's highest life expectancies.

Skyline of Hong Kong with a Chinese junk in the foreground

SMALL FAMILIES

China's population grows by millions each year. In 1979, to try to control the rising population, the government brought in policies to stop parents from having more than one child. As a result, many Chinese children do not have brothers and sisters, but this might change as a two-child policy was introduced in 2016.



PADDY FIELDS

Rice forms the basis of most Chinese meals. It grows in paddy fields in the southeast of the country. During the growing season, fields are flooded so farmers can grow more rice more quickly. In the drier regions, wheat is grown and used to make noodles, buns, and dumplings. Rice or wheat is combined with local vegetables, meats, and spices to create regional dishes.

